Moscow and Havana prospered. When he first became prime minister, Castro provided the same assurances he had given Herbert Mathews, including during an eleven-day visit to the United States in April 1959. He was received by enthusiastic crowds but mixed official reactions. President Eisenhower arranged to be away from Washington (playing golf), so Castro met Vice President Richard Nixon for a three-hour meeting. Nixon reported to Eisenhower that Castro was 'either incredibly naïve about communism or under communist discipline.'

Nevertheless, the Vice President believed that Fidel Castro 'has those indefinable qualities which make him a leader of men. Whatever we may think of him he is going to be a great factor in the development of Cuba and very possibly in Latin American affairs generally … But because he has the power to lead to which I have referred we have no choice but at least to try to orient him in the right direction.'[17]

Suffice to say, Eisenhower's attempts at orientation were not very robust. A year later the United States government began consideration of how to assassinate the Cuban Prime Minister.

The Cuban revolution represented the victory of Castro's 26 July Movement (named after the assault on the Moncada barracks on 26 July 1953). The Partido Socialista Popular (PSP), Cuba's Moscow-supporting communist party, played little part. Indeed, it had been highly critical of the Moncada attack. For Moscow's foreign policy elite, Castro was an unknown quantity. Foreign Ministry experts considered his revolution *petit bourgeois* in nature.[18] Until he came to power, Castro's relationship with communism was tenuous and ambiguous. His links to Moscow were non-existent. Fidel's socialism was, as he later put it, 'utopian'.[19]

This was not the case with his closet allies. His younger brother, Raúl was a secret member of the PSP, apparently unbeknownst to Fidel.[20] Another key figure in the revolution, Ernesto 'Che' Guevara, was also a committed communist, though one more receptive to Maoism than Marxism-Leninism. A graduate in medicine from the University of Buenos Aires, he too emerged as an iconic figure of the twentieth century (though with a less impressive beard). Che played a prominent role in promoting revolution across Central and South America (before his death at the hands